

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Sharp drop in detainees at ICE facility

Follows temporary restraining order requiring government to improve conditions at the site

By Madeline Buckley and Joe Mahr
Chicago Tribune

The number of detainees held at the U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement processing center in Broadview has dropped precipitously since a federal judge ordered the government to comply with requirements to improve conditions at the facility, with only four people held there as of Tuesday

morning.

The figure came out during a court hearing Tuesday at the Dirksen U.S. Courthouse, illuminating one aspect of the notoriously opaque operations at the west suburban facility. A government lawyer gave the court the new headcount at the controversial site, which has attracted protesters for months.

In a class-action lawsuit filed last month, attorneys called the

processing center a “black box” where detainees were crammed into dirty holding cells with not enough food and water, among other problems. U.S. District Judge Robert Gettleman ordered the Department of Homeland Security to comply with a temporary restraining order that mandated the government to clean the cells regularly, provide enough food and water as well as bedding to any detainee housed overnight.

The two-story building is meant as a temporary stopping point following an immigration arrest, but as the Trump adminis-

tration sought to increase deportations throughout the summer and during Operation Midway Blitz, the facility became so overcrowded, the lawsuit alleges, that detainees couldn’t lay down to sleep at night.

Attorneys for the detainees are seeking detailed data about the number of detainees processed and held at the facility over time, but during a daylong hearing earlier this month, detainees recounted times during which more than 150 people were crammed into a holding cell.

“I understand there are a lot

fewer people there,” Gettleman said during the hearing, adding that it is probably an “understatement.”

Attorneys for the government had objected to the temporary restraining order, arguing that it would limit its ability to enforce immigration law in Illinois, given that the Illinois TRUST Act prohibits the federal government from contracting with state or local facilities to house immigration detainees.

During a site visit last week

Turn to Broadview, Page 2



Epstein abuse survivor Haley Robson, center, reacts as the family of Virginia Giuffre, left, speaks during a news conference with lawmakers including Rep. Marjorie Taylor Greene, R-Georgia, right, on the Epstein Files Transparency Act on Tuesday in Washington. HEATHER DIEHL/GETTY

Congress OKs Epstein files’ release

Unanimous consent in Senate after bill clears House 427-1

By Stephen Groves
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — Both the House and Senate acted decisively Tuesday to pass a bill to force the Justice Department to publicly release its files on the convicted sex offender Jeffrey Epstein, a remarkable display of approval for an effort that had struggled for months to overcome opposition from President Donald Trump and Republican

leadership.

When a small, bipartisan group of House lawmakers introduced a petition in July to maneuver around Speaker Mike Johnson’s control of the House floor, it appeared a longshot effort — especially as Trump urged his supporters to dismiss the matter as a “hoax.”

But both Trump and Johnson failed to prevent the vote. The president in recent days bowed to political reality, saying he would sign the bill. And just hours after the House vote, senators agreed to approve it unanimously, skipping a formal roll call.

The decisive, bipartisan work

in Congress Tuesday further showed the pressure mounting on lawmakers and the Trump administration to meet demands that the Justice Department release its case files on Epstein, a well-connected financier who killed himself in a Manhattan jail while awaiting trial in 2019 on charges he sexually abused and trafficked underage girls.

For survivors of Epstein’s abuse, passage of the bill was a watershed moment in a yearslong quest for accountability.

“These women have fought the most horrific fight that no woman should have to fight. And they did it by banding together

and never giving up,” said Rep. Marjorie Taylor Greene as she stood with some of the abuse survivors outside the Capitol Tuesday morning.

“That’s what we did by fighting so hard against the most powerful people in the world, even the president of the United States, in order to make this vote happen today,” added Greene, a Georgia Republican.

In the end, only one lawmaker in Congress opposed the bill. Rep. Clay Higgins, a Louisiana Republican who is a fervent supporter of Trump, was the only “nay”

Turn to Files, Page 11

Authorities drop \$9.8M fine against Harmon

Illinois elections board remains deadlocked on fundraising case

By Dan Petrella
Chicago Tribune

Illinois partisan politics formally undermined a staff finding that state Senate President Don Harmon’s political fund violated campaign contribution limits last year, as state election authorities dropped a proposed fine of nearly \$10 million against the Oak Park Democrat.

For its second straight meeting, the eight-member Illinois State Board of Elections, composed of four Democratic appointees and four Republicans, remained split along party lines over whether to accept the recommendation of an impartial hearing officer who upheld the determination that Harmon’s main fundraising arm violated campaign contribution limits that Harmon himself had championed as a state lawmaker.

Prompted by a Chicago Tribune inquiry into the Friends of Don Harmon for State Senate campaign committee, elections board staff in June determined Harmon’s fund had accepted more than \$4 million in contributions above what was legally allowed ahead of last year’s election.

The matter was left in limbo last month, when the board was unable to reach the five-vote majority needed to either accept the hearing officer’s recommendation and levy staff’s proposed \$9.8 million

Turn to Harmon, Page 2



Harmon

INSIDE



CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Who’s staying, and who may be going

Shota Imanaga accepts his qualifying offer to stay with the Cubs, while, as expected, Kyle Tucker rejects his. **Chicago Sports**

Prepare your plates for Thanksgiving

Restaurants that make the holiday easy, wines with character and value and 35 reasons to save room for dessert. **Food & Health**

Advocate: ‘We have to fight like hell for what remains’

State urged to step up as EPA moves to cut wetlands protections

By Adriana Pérez
Chicago Tribune

After the U.S. Environmental Protection Agency announced Monday it is redefining the scope of the nation’s bedrock clean water law to limit the wetlands it protects from pollution and destruction, environmental groups are urging Illinois legislators to establish safeguards. The state has already lost 90% of its original wetlands to urban development and agriculture.

The Trump administration’s action builds on a 2023 Supreme Court ruling in Sackett v. EPA that sharply limited the U.S. government’s authority to regulate water pollution in certain wetlands, effectively stripping 72% of remaining wetlands in Illinois — more than 700,000 acres — of federal protections and

Turn to Wetlands, Page 4



Wetlands at the Milan Bottoms Preserve in Rock Island County on July 31. Milan Bottoms spans over 4,000 acres and is owned by a patchwork of state and federal agencies as well as private parties. Illinois has no statewide protections for wetlands on private land. E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

